

10 Abraham

The man who left everything at God's word, believed an impossible promise, and became "the Friend of God."

After the scattering at Babel, God speaks to one man and promises that through him "all families of the earth" will be blessed. Abram left his country with no map and no children, and lived in tents in a land he never owned. He waited twenty-five years for the promised son. He was brave and generous, but also fearful and impatient. Then God asked him to give up that son. Israel called him "our father," and the New Testament calls him the father of all who believe. His life shows what faith looks like when it has to wait.

At a glance

Name	Abram, "exalted father"; Abraham, "father of a great multitude"
Family	Son of Terah; wife Sarah; sons Ishmael, Isaac, and Keturah's six
When	Traditionally c. 2166–1991 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Ur, Haran, Bethel, Egypt, Hebron (Mamre), Beersheba, Moriah
Key people	Sarah, Lot, Hagar, Ishmael, Isaac, Melchizedek
Lifespan	175 years (Genesis 25:7)
Main passages	Genesis 11:26–25:11
New Testament	Romans 4; Galatians 3; Hebrews 11:8–19; James 2:21–23

"And he believed in the LORD; and he counted it to him for righteousness."

Genesis 15:6, KJV

The life of Abraham

Ages come from Genesis. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Abraham born c. 2166 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

In Ur	● Sets out with Terah Terah takes Abram, barren Sarai and Lot from Ur toward Canaan, but they settle in Haran, where Terah dies. <i>Genesis 11:26–32</i>
Age 75	● Leaves Haran God says, "Get thee out of thy country," promising land, a nation and blessing for all families. Abram goes. <i>Genesis 12:1–5</i>
In Canaan	● Believes the promise Still childless, Abram is shown the stars: "So shall thy seed be." He believes, and God makes a covenant. <i>Genesis 15:1–21</i>
Age 86	● Ishmael is born Sarai gives Abram her Egyptian maid Hagar, who bears Ishmael. <i>Genesis 16:1–16</i>
Age 99	● Renamed Abraham God renames Abram and Sarai, gives circumcision as the covenant sign, and promises a son through Sarah. <i>Genesis 17:1–27</i>
Age 100	● Isaac is born The LORD does for Sarah "as he had spoken," and she bears Isaac in their old age. <i>Genesis 21:1–7</i>
On Moriah	● The great test God tells Abraham to offer Isaac. The angel of the LORD stops him, and a ram is offered instead. <i>Genesis 22:1–19</i>
Age 175	● Dies Abraham dies "full of years." Isaac and Ishmael bury him beside Sarah at Machpelah. <i>Genesis 25:7–10</i>

Key activities

Stephen says God first called Abraham in Mesopotamia, before Haran (Acts 7:2–4). Many think Abram was not Terah's eldest son, though listed first.

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- 1** **Obedied the call.** He left country and kin for a land God had not yet shown him. *Genesis 12:1–5; Hebrews 11:8*

 - 2** **Built altars.** At Shechem, Bethel and Hebron he called on the name of the LORD. *Genesis 12:7–8; 13:18*

 - 3** **Passed off Sarai as his sister.** Afraid, he let Pharaoh and later Abimelech take her; God protected her. *Genesis 12:10–20; 20:1–18*

 - 4** **Gave Lot first choice.** To end strife he let his nephew choose; Lot took the plain near Sodom. *Genesis 13:5–12*

 - 5** **Rescued Lot.** He armed 318 trained servants and brought back the captives. *Genesis 14:12–16*

 - 6** **Honored Melchizedek.** He gave the priest-king a tenth and refused reward from Sodom's king. *Genesis 14:17–24*

 - 7** **Believed God.** With no child and no land, he trusted God's word. *Genesis 15:1–6*

 - 8** **Took a shortcut.** He had a child by Hagar, and years later sent her and Ishmael away, grieving. *Genesis 16:1–4; 21:9–14*

 - 9** **Welcomed strangers.** He served three visitors at Mamre; one was the LORD. *Genesis 18:1–15*

 - 10** **Pleaded for Sodom.** "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" *Genesis 18:22–33*

 - 11** **Offered Isaac.** Trusting that "God will provide himself a lamb," he named the place Jehovah-jireh. *Genesis 22:1–14*

 - 12** **Bought a grave.** The cave of Machpelah was the first land he owned in Canaan. *Genesis 23:1–20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abraham.

Old Testament

Genesis 11:26–25:11	The main account of his life
Exodus 3:6	"The God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob"
Joshua 24:2–3	Terah's family "served other gods"
Isaiah 41:8	God calls him "Abraham my friend"
Isaiah 51:2	"Look unto Abraham your father"

New Testament

Matthew 1:1	Jesus "the son of David, the son of Abraham"
John 8:56–58	"Before Abraham was, I am"
Romans 4; Galatians 3:6–9	Righteous by faith; father of all who believe
Hebrews 11:8–19	He went out "not knowing whither he went"
James 2:21–23	"He was called the Friend of God"
Echo: Romans 8:32	A father gives his own Son

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise Abram in Genesis 12:1–3, and what did he have to leave?
2. *Understand:* Abraham believed, yet lied and took shortcuts. What does that say about the faith God counts as righteousness?
3. *Apply:* What step of obedience are you putting off because you can't see the whole path?
4. *Apply:* Abraham let Lot choose first. Where could you give up your rights to keep peace?